

## THE PASHTUN WORLD

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Mountains Valleys Cities World

To understand Orakzai, it is also necessary to understand the wider world in which Orakzai identity developed.

The Orakzai are part of the larger Pashtun world — a diverse collection of communities connected by language, history, tribal relationships, cultural traditions, geography, and shared forms of social identity.

But the Pashtun world is not a single place.

It stretches across mountains, valleys, plains, cities, borders, and increasingly, the global diaspora.

For centuries, Pashtun communities have lived across areas that today fall within Afghanistan and Pakistan, with Pashto-speaking communities also present in parts of Iran and elsewhere.<sup>1</sup>

The modern political map does not completely describe the historical geography of these communities.

People, languages, families, and tribal networks existed before today's borders.

### THE LANGUAGE OF A PEOPLE

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Pashto is one of the most important elements connecting the wider Pashtun world.

It is an Eastern Iranian language with multiple dialects and regional varieties.<sup>2</sup>

Pashto is spoken across Afghanistan and Pakistan and by communities beyond the region.

Its vocabulary, poetry, oral traditions, proverbs, and everyday speech have helped preserve cultural memory across generations.

Language is therefore more than communication.

It can carry history. It can carry humour. It can carry poetry. It can carry family memory. And it can carry a sense of belonging.

For many Pashtuns, language remains one of the strongest cultural connections between generations.

## **A WORLD OF TRIBES**

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One of the distinctive features of traditional Pashtun society is the importance of tribal and clan relationships.

Pashtun tribal organization is complex. Different tribes and clans have their own histories, territories, genealogical traditions, political relationships, and internal structures.

The Orakzai are one part of this wider system.

Other major Pashtun tribal groupings include, among many others, Afridi, Shinwari, Mohmand, Khattak, Wazir, Mehsud, Yusufzai, Durrani, Ghilzai, and numerous smaller tribal and clan groups.<sup>3</sup>

These names should not be treated as a simple single family tree. Pashtun genealogy often combines historical memory, oral tradition, lineage narratives, and political relationships. The history of each group therefore deserves to be studied individually.

## **THE MOUNTAINS AND THE PLAINS**

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Geography has played an important role in Pashtun history. Mountain ranges, valleys, rivers, passes, and frontier routes shaped movement and settlement. The terrain could separate communities while also creating strong local identities.

Tirah is one example. Located within the mountainous region historically associated with the Orakzai and neighbouring communities, Tirah became an important geographical reference point in the history of the region.<sup>4</sup>

But the Pashtun world has never been limited to mountains. Pashtun communities have also lived in agricultural valleys, market towns, major cities, and commercial centres. Today, Pashtun life can be found in places very different from the traditional mountain environment.

## **PASHTUNWALI AND SOCIAL VALUES**

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Pashtunwali is commonly described as a traditional ethical and social framework associated with Pashtun communities. Concepts commonly discussed in relation to Pashtunwali include:

Melmastia — hospitality

Nanawatai — providing refuge or protection

Nang — honour

Badal — concepts of reciprocity, justice, or revenge depending on context

These concepts should not be treated as a rigid universal legal code followed identically by every Pashtun. Their meaning and importance can vary by community, generation, location, and circumstance.

Pashtun society has changed considerably over time. Education, urbanization, migration, state institutions, economic development, religion, technology, and global communication have all influenced contemporary Pashtun life. Tradition and change therefore exist together.

## **POETRY, MEMORY AND ORAL HISTORY**

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The Pashtun world has a powerful tradition of poetry and oral expression. Poetry has historically provided a way to express love, grief, honour, resistance, spirituality, politics, humour, and everyday life.

Stories and poems can travel between generations even when written records are limited. This makes oral history particularly important.

But oral history must also be handled carefully. A story preserved through generations can be culturally meaningful while still containing elements that historians may not be able to independently verify.

Respecting oral tradition does not mean treating every story as proven fact. It means preserving the story while also understanding its context.

## **A WORLD BEYOND BORDERS**

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The Pashtun world has changed dramatically during the modern era. Political borders divided communities that had previously interacted across a wider geographical landscape.

Migration then created new Pashtun communities in cities and countries far from their ancestral regions. Today, Pashtuns can be found across Pakistan and Afghanistan and in diaspora communities around the world.<sup>5</sup>

This has created a new form of Pashtun identity. A young Pashtun may grow up in Karachi, Islamabad, Lahore, Dubai, London, New York, or another global city. Their experience may be completely different from that of someone growing up in a remote mountain village. Yet both may still feel connected to Pashtun heritage. Identity can therefore survive geographical transformation.

## **THE ORAKZAI PLACE IN THE PASHTUN WORLD**

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Within this wider world, the Orakzai have their own history. Their traditional homeland, particularly the Tirah region and surrounding areas, forms an important part of that history. The Orakzai story cannot be separated completely from the wider history of Pashtun communities.

At the same time, Orakzai history should not be reduced to a general description of Pashtuns. Every tribe has its own experiences, its own memories, its own internal divisions, its own relationships with neighbouring communities, and its own historical development.

This book therefore approaches Orakzai identity from both directions:

**FROM THE INSIDE:** Family, birthplace, memory, community, and personal identity.

**FROM THE WIDER WORLD:** Pashtun history, language, geography, culture, and changing society.

Both perspectives are necessary.

## **THE MODERN PASHTUN**

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The Pashtun of the twenty-first century cannot be defined only through the image of the traditional tribal frontier.

Modern Pashtuns are students, engineers, doctors, entrepreneurs, farmers, artists, researchers, developers, teachers, business owners, public servants, scientists, and members of a global digital economy.

The modern Pashtun world contains both tradition and innovation. The same community that preserves centuries-old poetry can also produce software engineers. The same family that remembers an ancestral village can have children working in global technology companies.

The same cultural identity can exist alongside artificial intelligence, biotechnology, blockchain, finance, engineering, and modern education. This is not necessarily a contradiction. It is evolution.

## **THE FUTURE OF THE PASHTUN WORLD**

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The next chapter of Pashtun history will not be written only in mountains or villages. It will also be written in classrooms, laboratories, businesses, universities, technology companies, digital communities, and cities around the world.

The challenge for the next generation is not simply to preserve the past. It is to understand it well enough to build responsibly upon it.

Heritage can provide roots. Education can provide knowledge. Technology can provide tools. And young people can decide what comes next.

## ONE PEOPLE, MANY HORIZONS

### AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

I am Orakzai. But Orakzai exists within a larger story. Understanding that larger story makes my own identity more meaningful. The mountains of Tirah are one part of the picture. The Pashto language is another. Family memory is another. Pashtun history is another. And the modern global world is now part of the story as well. I do not see identity as a closed circle. I see it as a network. One that connects people to their past while giving them the freedom to build something new.